

Complaint Handling Procedure

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Audience: Claims and customer service staff

Effective: June 1, 2025

1. Scope

This procedure applies to any written or verbal expression of dissatisfaction from a policyholder or claimant about a coverage decision, claim handling delay, or payout amount, whether or not the word "complaint" is used.

2. Intake and Logging

Every complaint is logged in the complaint register within 1 business day of receipt, regardless of whether it appears to have merit. The log entry records the policy or claim number, the nature of the complaint, and the date received.

3. Response Timeline

Meridian Mutual acknowledges a logged complaint within 5 business days and provides a substantive written response — either resolving the complaint or explaining the next step — within 15 business days of receipt, consistent with Ohio's regulatory expectations for insurer responsiveness referenced in the Ohio Regulatory Reference document.

4. Complaints About a Coverage Decision

A complaint disputing a coverage denial or a payout amount is routed to a supervising adjuster who was not the original decision-maker for independent review. The reviewing adjuster re-examines the five-step adjudication sequence from the Claims Adjudication Guidelines — in particular, confirming the correct policy form version was used (Step 1) and that the payout computation was not manually altered (Step 4) — before either upholding or revising the original decision.

5. Complaints Alleging the Wrong Policy Version Was Used

Given that policy-version mismatch is a known risk (Claims Adjudication Guidelines, Step 1), a complaint that specifically alleges the wrong policy form or Declarations page was used is treated as a priority item: the reviewing adjuster confirms the Declarations page and form version in force on the date of loss within 2 business days, ahead of the standard 15-business-day response timeline.

6. Escalation to the Appraisal Process

If a complaint is specifically about the amount of a loss (rather than whether a loss is covered at all), and internal review does not resolve it to the policyholder's satisfaction, the policyholder is informed of their right to invoke the appraisal process under Policy Wording Section 8.2.

7. Records Retention

All complaint records, including the original complaint, the reviewing adjuster's findings, and the final response, are retained for a minimum of 5 years, consistent with the documentation requirements in the Claims Adjudication Guidelines, Section 4.